Marwari Migration and Dominance

In 1844, the *Bombay Times and Journal of Commerce*, now known as the *Times of India*, ran a brief piece titled ‘Beware of the Marwaries’, exhorting their readers to pay ‘special attention’ to the account of one Mr Punditrao:[44]

> These Marwaris leave their own country for the purpose of trading, and they are spread all over Hindostan. A Marwari’s shop may be seen in a hamlet, consisting of only four or five cottages; in fact, were you to search all Hindostan, it would be difficult to find an agricultural village without a Marwari. When they arrive here they commence by selling gram, and, in the course of four or five years, they become opulent bankers. The causes of this are their unjust dealings . . . Therefore, my advice to my countrymen is this, that they avoid entering into any transactions of this nature with such deceivers as these.

The newspaper did not take its own advice seriously. A century later, its ownership fell into the hands of a Marwari family. By then, the Marwari community and its power had extended beyond trading and moneylending to dominate the world of industry and big business. They would emerge as the most enigmatic, celebrated and vilified business community of India.

The puzzle about the Marwaris begins with the name. Marwar belongs to the western part of Rajasthan around Jodhpur, and yet a large number of Marwaris outside Rajasthan do not trace their roots to this region. Most Marwaris are, in fact, Shekhawatis, referring to a region in northern Rajasthan, close to Jaipur. It is here, for instance, that you will come across Pilani, the roots of the famous Shekhawati, or Marwari family, the Birlas. Further, Marwari in popular lingo does not refer only to a region but also to Banias or those who engage in commercial occupations. This is closely tied up with the Vaishya caste within the Hindu fold and the Jains outside it. Within them, there are three main divisions—Aggarwals, Maheshwaris and Oswals—which comprise around 6 per cent of Rajasthan’s population with distinct regional variations.[45] The Aggarwals are more prominent in northern Rajasthan while the other two are relatively more prominent in the western and southern parts of the state.[46] One could therefore be a Kolkata-based Shekhawati Aggarwal Jain or a Mumbai-based Jodhpuri Oswal Hindu. Such sub-group identities often matter in the close-knit marriage